



Photographs by MANEESH AGHOTRI

Throughout his career, Lok Janshakti Party (LJP) chief Ram Vilas Paswan has been known as the optimiser—the man who milks opportunity best. With just four MPs from the party, including himself, Paswan has made the most of it by bagging a berth in the Union Cabinet. In the post-poll scenario too, Paswan is largely expected to swim with Lalu and Mulayam but may not mind accepting a lifejacket thrown by the NDA if the only other option left is to sink with his new-found friends. While he is also on very cordial terms with the Left leadership, he may only hesitate joining a Left-prompted government if Mayawati's Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) is also on board. Currently, his party is contesting only 12 seats in Bihar, which may not allow this man with prime ministerial ambition to emerge a king-



### Mulayam Singh Yadav SP

**BY EMBRACING BJP OUTCAST KALYAN SINGH, THE SP CHIEF HAS ANGERED THE MUSLIM COMMUNITY, HIS MAIN VOTE BANK.**

**12** senior Samajwadi Party MPs have left the outfit in recent times.

maker after the elections. But in a post-election scenario where even a single MP party will have pretensions of being a kingmaker, Paswan may emerge a crucial element in case his LJP manages to win three or four seats. In such a situation, the Union minister for chemicals and fertilisers and steel can be a willing converter.

### ELECTORAL COMPULSIONS HAVE BROUGHT THE THREE FORMER FOES ON THE SAME PLATFORM

In Uttar Pradesh, Mulayam Singh Yadav faces his sternest test ever. Nearly a dozen of his MPs have deserted him in recent times and his Muslim support base is cracking. The dalliance with the Congress, which began in July last year during the trust vote, is all but over. The induction of BJP discard Kalyan Singh into the Samajwadi Party (SP) is turning out to be a liability for him. To bolster his party's chances, Yadav fielded Sanjay Dutt, but the Supreme Court rejected the matinee idol's candidature, leaving Yadav to rework his strategy.

Contrary to their claims of fighting the polls together and jointly addressing election rallies in the two states, the three leaders are focused upon